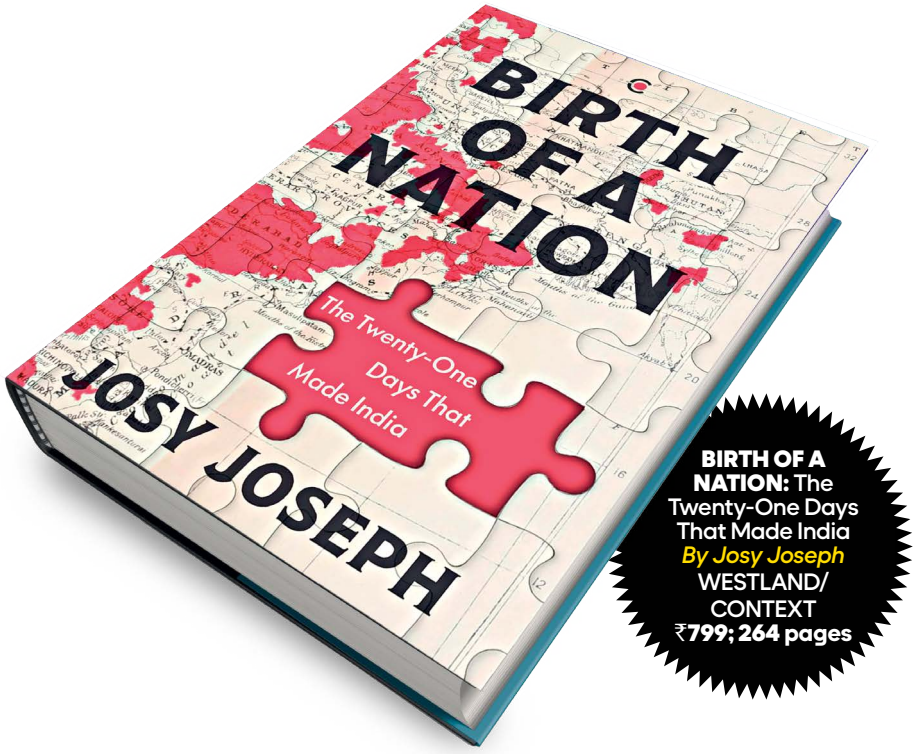
BOOKS ▼

THE INTRIGUE BEHIND INDEPENDENCE

JOSY JOSEPH REVISITS THE POLITICAL MANOEUVRING AND BEHIND-THE-SCENES NEGOTIATIONS THAT NEARLY DERAILED THE MAKING OF A UNITED INDIA



BIRTH OF A NATION: The Twenty-One Days That Made India
By Josy Joseph
WESTLAND/ CONTEXT
₹799; 264 pages

India might be a large and stable democracy today, but 79 years ago, this was hardly a sure thing. The dominant version of history tells us how Sardar Patel assisted by V.P. Menon sutured together 565 princely states to cement the Indian union. But it was a far more arduous, nerve-wracking and complicated process than we account for. The 21-day period in the lead-up to August 15, 1947, is the subject of investigative journalist Josy Joseph's new book *Birth of a Nation*—a period of intrigues, leaks, double-dealing and hectic negotiations.

Joseph draws on previously neglected documents to pull together a compelling narrative that focuses on lesser-known figures and episodes in the build-up to Independence. His story opens on July 25, 1947, with an assassination attempt on the Diwan of Travancore, Sir C.P. Ramaswami Iyer. Iyer was plotting for independence whilst also tactically organising several princely states against joining India. Over the taut 227-page narrative, we are taken through the manoeuvres and ploys of Bhopal, Jodhpur, Junagadh and other defiant royals.

Indian officials had to navigate a web of other complications; some British officials were slyly supporting the princes, and Jinnah himself was actively in touch with some others. Joseph assembles an unheralded cast, beyond "the towering personalities of that period". We discover "the remarkable stories of the many who, in the shadows cast by these titans, toiled quietly for the emergence of a united India". For instance, the Diwan of Hyderabad state displayed exceptional courage by leaking news to the centre about Hyderabad's possible moves.

There's a real sense of chaos and tension that permeates the pages—and shows us how close the subcontinent came to splintering. Rich in anecdotes and undergirded by solid archival work, Joseph's book is a valuable addition to our understanding of modern India. ■

THE 21-DAY PERIOD IN THE LEAD-UP TO AUGUST 15, 1947, IS THE BOOK'S STORY, WHICH OPENS WITH AN ASSASSINATION ATTEMPT ON THE DIWAN OF TRAVANCORE

—Bhavya Dore